to dust in a day. Shockwaves of communal fury spread across South Asia, leaving thousands dead and hundreds of Hindu temples in Pakistan and Bangladesh pulverized. India's High Court blocked the erection of a new temple on the mosque's old platform, and Indian troops were stationed around the desecrated area to prevent any further provocation to violence.

A decade later, Hindutva leaders vowed to erect Rama's new birth-temple at the old mosque's site, on 15 March 2002, celebrated as Rama's birthday. Hindu craftsmen had been working without pay for ten years to carve out and polish every stone and marble statue of the new temple, and all those parts were carefully arranged around the site. Fearing violence, however, Prime Minister Vajpayee and Deputy Prime Minister L.K. Advani deployed 15,000 of India's best riot-control police in Ayodhya shortly before the birth celebration began. Many Hindu workers lost heart then and decided to return home, leaving Ayodhya on the Sabarmati Express in late February, stopping at Godhra station. There a few Hindus stepped down for tea, bumping into a mad Muslim railwayman. He cursed them and threw a flaming torch through the window of their carriage. Other Muslims joined in, trapping fifty-six Hindu men, women, and children, all of whom were burned to death inside the blazing steel coach.

The aftermath proved even worse. As the news spread across Gujarat, thousands of Hindutva thugs raced after any Muslims they could find, setting fire to their beards and turbans and beating them to death if they had not burned to death first. Gujarat's BJP chief minister, Narendra Modi, did nothing to stop the massacre, leaving more than two thousand Muslims to be slaughtered in the next few days before the fires of Hindu rage abated. Modi gave no orders to arrest or prosecute any of the murderers, remarking to Hindu colleagues in provincial power that "Jinnah was right! Muslims should all leave India and go to Pakistan!" Modi was reelected that year with his largest majority and soon became the political hero of every reactionary Hindu group in India and many wealthy overseas friends of the BJP, who tout him as their favorite future candidate for prime minister. Most Indians proved more sensible, however, and elected the liberal secular Congress party and its progressive allies in 2004. This United Progressive Alliance coalition not only prevailed again in the 2009 national elections, but the Congress party itself almost doubled its lead over the BJP, nearly winning a Lok Sabha majority on its own. Dr. Farooq Abdullah of Kashmir, moreover, was brought into Prime Minister Singh's Cabinet as its minister for new